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finally released. It clung to what was left of the area, eating through the concrete and pitting the metal. Screams rose in the haze, only to be cut short as their lungs melted.

He felt something behind him and he turned, on the ready as he saw a jagged smear in the air. Space wavered like heat off metal, a thin tear dragging itself across his vision. The hairs on his neck prickled under his harness as he grabbed her by the throat, her struggling figure slowly taking shape. “Pathetic,” he rasped.

Lyra Solvyn spilled out of phase, her face and hair already eaten thin, her fingers clawing at his hand as her face contorted from the lack of air. Her eyes were bright with fury, and he could smell the fear rolling off her.

He extended her shaking body over the pit that used to be their Hero Agency, the fires boiling wildly as the acid fed the flames.

“Where. Is. Vexal. Ophedius?” he punctuated every word quietly.

Her throat twitched in his hand and she tried to rasp something, and he released his thumb slowly, giving her room to wheeze out words.

Instead she bared her teeth, grinning wildly. He felt his anger finally surge over, his fist closing on nothing but vapour as his mutation turned her body into a falling drizzle of hissing liquid. The fire roared up around his hand, colliding with her blood and flaring white-hot before snuffing out.

The metal around him screamed and he heard the T.E.B. sirens in the distance. He walked back along the fractured platform, the Halflight flag still standing precariously amidst the ruins of the main building. He smiled to himself before tapping into his comtech and launching his body into the air. His boots just dusted the edges of the transport as he landed, the lieutenants and

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soldiers alike scrambling back in fear. Ekros hovered at the rail, his eyes brimming with excitement as he waited for the go.

Fane nodded at him, the rat rushing to the controls, disengaging autopilot and rocketing the transport out of the Verge. Fane looked over the awed group in front of him, pride bursting in his chest as he marvelled at the fear and love in his creations' eyes.

“I will be releasing you throughout Titan,” he boomed, pacing slowly. “I need Vexal Ophedius and the Operative known as Nyx. **Dead or alive.**”

Chapter 45

The Halflight Hero Agency was nothing but a smouldering hole. Nyx stood at the edge of what used to be the main building, the cold, acidic air whipping past her face. The entire front of the block had corroded in on itself, a slurry of metal and concrete melting into the dense jungle. Acid had chewed the edges down to a slump-rim, the heavy vapour still rising in lazy curls around the boiled stone. The smell of blood and waste hung heavy in the air with the smoke.

She squinted her eyes up at what was left of their banner, still hanging from the flagpole almost as a mockery. The cloth itself was half-melted together into a jagged fringe, the red and white barely visible beneath the black blistering through the fabric. She swallowed hard, her respirator humming on the bridge of her nose as she tried to steady her heartbeat.

She felt like she was in a nightmare. She and Darius had been celebrating their victory against the Cryothorne monster, taking a much-wanted break. It had almost been a peaceful morning back in Helion, and she had hoped that things would finally calm down.

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Emergency sirens seared her ears as she turned her head, trying to see into the wet green for any survivors. Cryo-foam cannons hissed as they attempted to automatically put out the fires, a meagre effort against the acid-fuelled flames.

“Nyx!” Darius’s voice rang out behind her. She dragged her eyes away from the crater and turned, her body feeling like lead.

Darius stood a few paces back in full gear, his helmet flaming brightly. His hammers were fully charged, pulsing visibly in his hands. Ash streaked his face as he clearly struggled to find the words. Behind him, Voxx hovered half an inch above the cracked concrete, his luminous armour dimmed to a restrained silver. His scythe stood in a massive, radiant arc at his side; his sword was still sheathed, but ready.

“How many?” Her voice sounded strange to her ears.

Darius’s jaw flexed, and he waited a moment before answering. “Two hundred and nineteen dead and counting.”

She stared at him, the words echoing through her body as if he had just punched her.

“They pulled who they could from the perimeter... but the response was largely too late.”

She looked back at the smoldering crater, the acid haze mixing with her tears and burning her face. She could almost still see Lyra moving about the compound, her red jacket half-zipped, her purple hair always cut in her short, asymmetrical bob.

Lyra had been there the day she met Vexal. The day she had forced herself out of the void in her quest for vengeance. Was this vengeance? Was this what she had started?

Dizziness hit her so fast her knees gave out from under her. She had let him walk away from her twice, alive.

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Voxx's voice cut into her thoughts. "T.E.B. forensics have confirmed that it was Fane Dryst."

Her fingernails bit into her palms as she tried to steady herself. Mobile field-units had already gone up along the outer avenues, the wind carrying the acid through the Outer Pulse, increasing its victims. Floodlights cut harsh cones through the haze and smoke, illuminating deep piles of body bags in rows along what had been the street.

Their comtechs pinged in unison, the sharp sound cutting through the rush in her ears. She flicked her fingers over the display, the message causing bile to rise in her throat:

MULTIPLE APEX-CLASS HOSTILES CONFIRMED SIGHTINGS: HELION PRIME SUBRINGS AND MOVING NORTH AT 16 CLICKS. FORGEDEEP SECTOR 16B HEADING NORTH-EAST AT 12 CLICKS. STRATOS GATE CENTRAL VERTICAL ZONE HEADING SOUTH-WEST AT 22 CLICKS. BLACKROOT VERGE PULSE BORDER HEADING SOUTH-EAST AT 10 CLICKS. THIS IS AN ALL-HANDS-ON-DECK SITUATION. ALL UNITS AT FULL DISPATCH.

Voxx stamped over the rubble and hauled her to her feet. "We're the closest to the Outer Pulse. We need to get it together now!"

She nodded, wiping her face furiously.

"Let's move," he snapped.

She didn't respond as Darius rushed past her in a blur, the heat from his armour cutting through the cold, acidic wind. She followed automatically, her boots slipping slightly on the warped concrete as the world around her tunnelled. He shouted orders in front of her, but her

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eyes were glued to the piles of body bags, her stomach lurching dangerously at the sickeningly sweet stench of human flesh.

The perimeter of the damage was a swarm of T.E.B. medics, all trying to work around the worst of the victims scattered throughout the unstable rubble. Her eyes stung with the residue of the acid, and she tried to make out any familiar faces as they approached the temporary flight pad. It sat on what used to be a freight platform, now eaten down to the flat rock and emergency anchors. Darius's military-grade transport was still hot with a T.E.B. enforcer on standby, his visor pulled low against the smog.

"Commander! Captain! It's a pack of Apex constructs heading across the Outer Pulse!" the enforcer shouted as they approached.

"A pack?" Voxx was incredulous, and Nyx felt the adrenaline race through her body.

"It looks as if they are trying to breach the Null Zone and slip inland. If they get footholds, they will be almost impossible to uproot!"

They stood there mute for a beat, the sirens screaming as more and more sectors were compromised.

"We will exterminate them before they get there," Darius said, the first to move into the waiting transport.

The enforcer saluted as Voxx followed without a word, the ramp snapping shut behind them. Darius didn't wait for them to buckle in; instead, he kicked the skiff off the platform and into the air with such force she felt her teeth click.

She let her emotions fuel her energy as she watched the burning jungle pass beneath her. It seemed like the winter season was also a dry season for most of the Verge. The massive trees

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burned like torches in the night, the rivers of melting fungus cutting a neon scar through the darkness.

The transport rattled slightly as Darius drove it harder, weaving in and out of traffic and buildings, taking the shortest routes possible.

Voxx stood braced with one hand clamped overhead and the other flicking through the terminal. “Nyx. Visual feed, now,” he snapped.

She immediately focused her vision, moving closer to see the display. Shaky footage from drone units flicked past in quick cuts, and she watched in tense silence.

Hulking shapes tore through the Outer Pulse, their bodies all plated with armour and of impossible heights. She let out a rush of breath as smaller shapes darted around their legs. Dregs with jagged limbs and bodies tearing apart anyone with an energy signature. Cannibals.

“It is a pack of nine primary monsters. Taller, but lighter than the ones we fought in Aetherion.” Voxx’s jaw was tight as he ground out the words. “We have no idea how many smaller Dregs are on the loose.”

“They are *eating* the people!” Her voice was a whisper.

“Confirmed. They are pushing for the old Dominion Sector One,” Voxx continued. “The Null Zone. This is the worst place this can happen. They can survive in the surface area, but there are no atmosphere domes, no regulators, no shelters. We will be taking the brunt of Titan's surface the entire time we are out there. If they break through and slip inland, we lose containment and they will have access to planet-wide maintenance tunnels and Catalyst Wells.”

“Will we have reinforcements?” Darius called over his shoulder, eyes never leaving the viewport.

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“Since this is happening planet-wide... no.” Voxx sighed, finally looking at her. “I’m not going to sugarcoat it; this doesn’t look good. We have to intercept them and annihilate the horde before they breach the Null boundary.”

She nodded, trying to focus her thoughts. She reached for her hips, unhooking her twin sickles and allowing her energy to flood through the grips. The resonance hummed through her bones, each blade circling in gentle arcs around her body.

Voxx reached for his own scythe and rolled his shoulders. She felt the transport shift into autopilot and Darius joined them at the hatch.

“Nyx,” Voxx said, “you need to slow down the faster pack edges and warp as many civilians as you can to safety. Valkyrie and I will work on taking down the primary constructs.”

“Understood,” both she and Darius echoed. Darius was looking at her closely through his visor, but she focused on the display, memorising the safety zones already established and the places that looked the most damaged.

“Approaching destination,” the transport's autonomous voice alerted them in a flat tone.

Darius opened the hatch and the burning Verge rose to meet them. Trees burned everywhere, obscuring the civilian housing in tangles of collapsed fungus.

She and Darius stepped off the edge in unison as Voxx took to the sky, the thick, chemical-laced smoke rushing around her ears in a roar. A heartbeat later, they slammed into the ground below, Darius sending a shockwave through the Dregs with his already-drawn hammers.

She swung her sickles out as she spun into the torrent of rampaging Dregs, the air around her blades warping as she cut through the mutated body in front of her. Their blood had a weird acid tinge, and she dodged through the mess nimbly, looking desperately for any survivors.

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Above her, Voxx cut a silver arc across the sky. His scythe swept wide across the neck of the biggest monster, its towering body swaying and snapping in pain. It stumbled, sending Dregs flying, and she quickly warped them into the fires, their screams joining the painful symphony of noise.

“Outer sector evac still incomplete,” a voice crackled over her comtech. “Bloomline lane has three civilian clusters. They are holed up with an Echelon whose energy is draining fast!”

“Operative Nyx en route,” she responded quickly, changing her trajectory. The way was blocked by a ribbed centipede, its metal and flesh oozing a bright green sludge that ate away everything around it. She cursed under her breath as it reared its body at her. A flash of guilt swept through her body as she saw the barely humanoid face hanging from its neck. It cried out in pain as its path lurched, its legs ripping deep grooves into the ground. Electric and gas lines erupted violently, and she braced herself with a shield of her energy before charging the monster head-on.

“Nyx,” Darius warned, his voice coming sharply through her comtech.

She felt him before she saw him. Heat built up behind her like a pressure wave before he soared into the monster, his hammers sending waves of Magma crushing through its metal exterior. With its attention off her, she warped to the other side of it, trying to continue on her path. She heard the monster fall behind her, but she stayed focused, weaving in and out of the rampaging Dregs with her sickles. Blood burned her skin, but she didn’t slow her momentum, her body trying to heal and defend itself from the toxins at the same time, making everything before her hazy.

“Bloomline open lane is coming up on your right,” her comtech crackled, and she took a sharp turn into a service lane, half-choking on the smoking fungus her respirator failed to keep

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out. Dregs were pounding on a flickering energy shield relentlessly, and she didn't hesitate, lancing through them with brutal efficiency. Three clusters of civilians were hiding under a row of overturned transport pods, their green faces peeking out at the sudden lack of sound. A single Echelon officer stood in the centre of them, his energy braced as the shield, but his body was shaking so violently it clearly wasn't going to hold.

"Keep your shield up!" she yelled, her blades carving through the next rush of Dregs. She bent the ground around them, spearing limbs and separating bodies with the burnt earth. Whirling around, she mustered her energy; she needed to warp everyone at once, and safely. If she misjudged a single thing, she could scatter bodies across dozens of different sectors or into nowhere at all.

The shield flickered before snapping, and she felt the ground rattle as the scent of so many humans drove the Dregs into a frenzy. She felt her wrists snap as she pushed harder, the downed transports warping with the survivors in her desperation.

She felt the hair rise on her neck, whirling just in time to stop the next onslaught of desperate Dregs. A glimpse of white closed in on them, obliterating what was left in a mighty beam of light.

"Nyx!" Voxx barked sharply as he passed her. "Don't just stand there! **Move!**"

She staggered to the side on instinct, breath rasping harshly through her mask. She instinctively ducked as his scythe obliterated the wave of Dregs in a severing column of light.

"Civilian cluster status?" he demanded, banking in a cloud of smoke.

"Evacuated!" She swallowed hard, almost choking on the air.

His comtech crackled to life. "Multiple monsters converging on the ridge. Requesting immediate backup."

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It was Darius.

“Send the coordinates,” she snapped, already pulling her map up and preparing her energy to warp.

The map flared; a red smear marked where the Verge ended in an underground slant. “Commander! Nyx! You have to target the back end,” Darius's voice came in sharp. “Multiple monsters are approaching the maintenance ridge. I’m holding the line, but we need to pick them off from the back!”

“Understood.” She was already moving over the rough terrain towards Voxx.

“Can you warp?” he asked sharply as the heat from his wings fanned her face, a blessed relief from the acidic air.

“Yes,” she answered, feeling her energy surge in response to her reply. She reached out for him without hesitating, feeling his energy as she warped toward the distant outline of the ridge. Space folded around them, and she felt Voxx’s gauntlet clamp on her shoulder. For a heartbeat, her mind slipped, his hand bringing back a fragment of a memory, before she sharpened her focus, arriving in a rush of thin air.

She was thankful that Voxx was there to steady her; they were right on the ridgeline, but it was torn away and jagged beneath her boots. Beyond it, the Null Zone stretched out in a dead band of land and sky that looked drained of colour. The usual low hum of Titan’s atmospheric shields was gone; instead, there was a shrill, constant whistle of the harsh planetary wind.

Darius was twenty metres ahead of them, a solitary blaze of blue-orange standing between the open Zone and a horde of monsters. His armour was venting heat in visible waves as the monsters and Dregs struggled to get past the heat. His hammers crashed mercilessly through

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the Dregs, Magma detonating out of the impact and chewing through their thick hides. His face was contorted, focused in an angry scowl.

Up close, the main monster was more terrifying than anything she had seen before. Much taller, this monster towered a good thirty feet in the air, multiple legs and arms jointed around its body for protection, armour layered over every targetable surface. Its core glowed an angry green, and vapour oozed heavily from its gaping mouth.

Nyx felt her vision waver on the edges as the pressure of the gravity and the adrenaline threatened to make her pass out.

“One monster at a time,” Voxx said sharply, as if sensing her terror. She nodded, surging forward, cutting through the thin air around the Dregs. Limbs grabbed at her, but she twisted her sickles protectively around her, the energy lancing off in waves, cutting the Dregs down in their tracks.

The spray of acid melted her respirator off, the pieces falling off in a crumble from the heavy acid. Her next breath stung her lungs, and her mutation fought to keep up. She slammed into the colossal monster's front leg, sending her sickles and body into a shearing twist that tore its leg apart with a wet crunch. It screamed in pain, the metallic roar setting her teeth on edge. It stumbled momentarily before its lidless eyes roved frantically around, looking for its target.

“Now!” Voxx’s voice cut through the pandemonium as light and Magma cleaved through the air in a perfect arc. It severed the monster's neck and spine, the momentum carrying the creature back onto the remaining Dregs.

The Dregs' screams turned desperate as they saw the tide turning against them, their efforts doubling as they tried to escape into the Null Zone. They made quick work of the remaining Dregs, her mind numb to their screams as the lack of oxygen began to slow her

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movements and thoughts. Soon there was only silence on the ridge, piles of smouldering Dreg fragments, their acid blood eating away their flesh. None had crossed over the ridge.

She was shaking as a low-oxygen alert went from yellow to red on her visor, the fires burning what little oxygen was left in the wind. She pulled her helmet off, dragging in a deep breath as she heard Darius and Voxx slowly drop down to the surface. They were discussing their next strategy, but she couldn't focus on their words. Alerts crossed their comtechs in unison: T.E.B. requesting backup at another location, the Dregs trying to breach the Null Zone at another entry point. She knew whenever her adrenaline wore off, she would be exhausted and left to think about Lyra, about Vexal, about what Fane would do next. But for now, they would keep pushing, trying to contain this disaster.

Chapter 46

The transport was shuddering hard from the damage it had sustained, and Nyx's teeth clicked together painfully. The motor whined, and she fought to keep her balance in the turbulent winds above Helion's Southline. Smoke covered the normally pristine city in a dirty cloak of haze, heavy enough so that even the cockpit glass was streaked with soot.

She counted the hours she had been on duty, almost a full forty-eight had passed since heading off the monsters at the end of the Verge. Somewhere between then and now, time had blended into a haze of blood and violence.

The transport's bay had been turned into a makeshift war room; the walls were covered in tactical projections, and red flares marked active engagements. A large portion of the map was red. The Null Zone was traced in a thick, pulsing line of blue, and three Grymworms were outlined to be moving straight for it from three different directions.

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“We have lost visuals with the Southline teams,” General Titus Valkyrie was spewing, his face flickering on the corner screen. “Every time we get a sector pinned down, they dive and change trajectory! We cannot sustain this amount of foundational damage!”

“Well, we simply don’t have the luxury of dispatching more resources to Forgedeeep,” High Chancellor Mereen snapped from her projection. “Status on King’s unit?”

Static hissed momentarily, and Nyx flinched inwardly, fearing another dead signal, but finally the General flickered onto the screen. He looked worn out, his normally bright uniform dull and heavily torn. His eyes focused on them through the feed before he spoke in a strained voice: “The North Slope’s been overrun. The Solaris team bought T.E.B. evac some time, but we’re down operatives on both teams.”

“Where are we on the cause of this?” Voxx asked in a clipped tone.

“We took live samples and sent them to Dr. Vaelith. But right now we know that the Dregs are spinning out in waves, probably a toxin being released in the lower sectors.”

Rhea’s face lit up in the upper-left corner. “The compound is an epigenetic accelerant. It’s spiking mutation conduction and boosting regeneration. Essentially turning the Dregs into mindless monsters, forcing their bodies into a death spiral.”

Nyx felt her fingers cut into her palms as the new images of the spun-out Dregs flashed across the screen.

“Is there any non-lethal way to reverse the effects?” Mereen’s voice cut in, speaking what was on the mind of every Council member.

“Yes,” Rhea answered hastily before backtracking. “I have synthesised a possible antidote, but the long-term effects are uncertain.”

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“We don’t have time to play ethics here!” General Valkyrie barked angrily. “I am under active siege with three Nova-tiered organics heading straight for the Null Zone. I say we end it now before we give them access to all of Titan!”

The other counsellors present murmured their agreement, and Nyx felt her blood run cold. She glanced at Darius, then Voxx, but both of their faces were impassive, their thoughts hidden behind impenetrable masks.

“General. Commander,” Mereen said after a beat. “I’m sure General Valkyrie can agree that given the risk of a full Null breach, the time has come to authorise the full might of the Apex Corps. We halt all evacuation procedures and focus solely on containment.”

Murmurs of shock and agreement echoed throughout the Council. “That’s the equivalent of mass murder!” one of the Verge delegates gasped.

Nyx felt her stomach twist into a sickening knot as her eyes found the map again, noting that whole sectors would see the potential fallout.

“I second that recommendation,” General Valkyrie interjected, dragging her attention back to his screen. “We grant temporary immunity to the Apex Corps. Neutralise the enemy at all costs.”

“The antidote—” Darius started to speak, the temperature of his body slowly rising.

“Is untested and, more importantly, unapproved,” Mereen said with a heavy sigh. “What if it has an even worse effect? What if we cause more damage than good? We cannot promise the future of Titan on an experimental formula.”

“I only need a few hours,” Rhea interjected. “Ekros and I can combine datasets and double production and variants.”

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“My facilities can begin manufacturing for clinical dispersal immediately!” Dr. Ekros chirped from another panel. “I can’t guarantee full reversal of every contaminated person, but we can hope to see at least an 87.3 percent biological rehabilitation in the infected persons. If this works...”

“We are running out of time,” King finally said, the Council members hushing immediately. “If we fail to hold off the breach, we will lose a third or more of Helion to Fane.”

The weight of his words hung in the silence, and guilt hit her like a blow in the ribs. She should have killed him when she was alone with him; she should have never trusted him.

“I can retrieve the antidote,” Darius finally spoke up, murmurs immediately erupting. “I can be there before the doctors finish the first batch and begin distribution across the field teams myself.”

“Absolutely not!” the Forgedeeep General started, but the High Chancellor cut him off sharply. “Approved.” She looked him directly in the eyes. “But if it does not work on the first recipients, we do it our way. That way, regardless of the outcome, we officially tried.”

Nyx saw Rhea go to argue, but stop herself. “Understood,” she said before immediately leaving the call, Ekros following suit with a curt nod.

Darius stood, opening the back bay door, his personal transport already hovering below them. “I’m heading to Helion now,” he said with a curt salute before dropping out of the transport in a rush of acidic air and smoke.

The feeds began to cut one by one as the delegates and officials vanished behind encrypted fades. Mereen was last; her eyes lingered a moment on Voxx before finding Nyx's, her eyes narrowing as Nyx felt an uncomfortable shiver slide down her spine in the silence.

“Three hours,” she said finally before cutting her feed.

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The ground groaned beneath her boots as the structural supports shifted and cracked from the stress of the increased tremors. She dodged falling debris as she looked for women and children taking shelter in the collapsed buildings, pulling the survivors out carefully before warping them back to a field clinic location on the other side of the Verge.

Her world had narrowed to the next acid-ridden breath, her mind fraying around the edges from exhaustion. Around her, the lights of the T.E.B. units flickered faintly in the poisonous haze, barely still functioning as search and rescue. She checked her comtech as bands of worry and exhaustion tightened around her chest.

2 HOURS, 25 MINUTES

Where was he? She turned, searching the hazy sky desperately. They were supposed to be getting help by now at the very least. She saw Voxx pause mid-strike as his comms crackled to life. His eyes went blank for a second before he flipped the channel open, and Nyx heard Mereen's cold voice in her ear:

“King’s team has sustained substantial losses. All the delegates and critical personnel have been evacuated. I am ordering you to end this. Now, Commander.” The line went dead.

Her eyes shot to Voxx, but he was already giving the disengage commands. She cut across the rubble towards him. “Commander Voxx.”

He didn’t answer. She raised her voice, the acid from the air causing her to cough slightly. “Commander Voxx!”

“She said it’s done.” He turned sharply toward her. “You heard her. Now—”

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“But there are still civilians out here.” She pointed behind her, where T.E.B. officers were still dragging unconscious children from cover, one of the officers limping badly.

“We have three Nova-tier threats inbound and the district's gone. We need to contain this **now**,” he ground out, turning away from her.

She stepped in front of him, squinting up at him in the haze. “You wouldn’t do this if it was your people! You are only leaving them here because they are Dregs!” Her heart thumped in her chest painfully, a nagging feeling of fear creeping up her spine.

“*Excuse me?*” His voice was chilling, and he lowered his head slightly.

“If this was your sector or Helion, you wouldn’t just leave them here!” She pushed on, ignoring the warning on his face. “Darius is still on the way with the antidote. We can—”

“My **sector?**” Voxx spat, cutting her off. “You think I have been eating blood and acid for two days straight while hauling bodies out of this never-ending firestorm to let it all go to waste on a fantasy we can save a few more lives at the risk of millions if Fane gets to the Null?!”

She felt anger flare in her chest, her vision sharpening. “I am not going to do it until Darius gets back,” she turned from him. “If you're in such a hurry to kill people, do it yourself.”

“Valkyrie isn’t coming.” His voice was curdled with venom. “We are running out of time, and once again you’ll be calling me when everything falls apart.”

“Well, what else is the AAN’s loyal lapdog for except to bend and heel whenever they tell you to. Regardless of who it hurts.” she spat back.

He stiffened, his fist curling tightly and his wings flaring. She could tell what she said had affected him, but she had to. She needed him to wait and at least give Rhea and Darius a chance to get an antidote.

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Voxx stared at her quietly before walking back to her until their toes touched. “**Fine.**” He lowered his face until he was barely an inch from her, his silver eyes raging. “We will wait, but if Valkyrie isn’t back and this backfires, I have to carry out my orders whether you like it or not. And you are taking responsibility for this. Not me. **You.** You need to pick a side, Myth, before more people die.”

She recoiled as if he had struck her as he stormed off in a flurry of white wings. Hearing her name out of his mouth again shook her to her core. She turned back to the chaos around her, her mind struggling to focus, her throat closing up with guilt. She turned her face to the sky, blinking her tears back as she scanned the cloudy green and orange hues for any sign of Darius’s transport. Or anybody. But there was nothing. The toxic wind whipped at her face, and she heard a child scream, snapping her body into action. She had time to fall apart later; right now, she had to save everybody she could before time ran out.

As she worked, the minutes crawled by, her eyes constantly shifting between her comtech and the disaster around her. Her gloves were slick with blood and grime, and her knees buckled more than once as she picked carefully through the ruins of what might have once been a housing unit. She found victim after victim, warping them to safety as the continuous drain of energy left her more and more unsteady.

She braced herself against a fallen girder as she tried to steady her breathing after a particularly shaky warp, her pulse thundering in her ears. She glanced at her comtech again, the faint outline of the timer counting up blurring before her eyes focused. Two hours and twenty-six minutes had passed, and still nothing. No message, no ping, and barely any signal.

She tapped the com line again. “Captain Valkyrie, come in. Requisition status report.”

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The line buzzed momentarily before going dark again. She blinked back tears and tried again. “Darius. Please. Come in, where are you?” She clenched her jaw hard enough she felt her teeth shift, the sickening feeling of déjà vu settling into her bones. Her mind flashed back to Aetherion, and she grimaced, the pain from that day still fresh in her bones.

She saw a T.E.B. officer stumble in the haze, his face blistering from the overexposure. She used that opportunity to push herself back into gear, warping the officer to the med tent before he could argue. The Verge T.E.B. unit was down to scraps, and the official safety zone had collapsed hours ago, the promised reinforcements never arriving.

The ground shuddered beneath her boots again, nearly knocking her off balance as she reached to warp to civilians she spotted huddling in a collapsed corridor, her arms burning from the strain and energy. Blood pounded in her ears, the smell of melting metal and ammonia flooding her senses as she tried to take a deep breath to steady herself. Her suit filters were failing, and her breathing mask had long since given out. Frustrated, she ripped it off her face, savouring the burn of the acid in her nose as the wind whipped around her violently.

She checked her comtech again: **2 HOURS, 31 MINUTES**. Her hand hovered for a second before hitting the call line again. “Captain Valkyrie, report in..”

She was met with the faint crackle of static before the line went dead. A scream drew her attention, and she forced her aching legs to move, half-sprinting toward the sound. A dirty and bleeding child was trapped under a bent stairwell, a T.E.B. officer working in vain to free them with one arm while his other arm dangled broken at his side. Nyx didn’t hesitate, absorbing the stairwell and grabbing the child before the surrounding debris could collapse around her. The officer looked at her in relief, and she gave him a gentle nod before warping them both to safety.

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As soon as they were gone, she felt a sharp stab of pain in her side, like a stitch or a hunger pang. She cried out before biting her tongue, seeing Voxx move faintly in the smog ahead. He looked as beat-down as she felt, carrying civilians and T.E.B. alike out of the wreckage, piling up bodies, and executing infected Dregs that were too dangerous to save.

She clenched her jaw, glancing at her comtech again before turning away, spotting a struggling trio of T.E.B. officers. They were trying to open a fallen transport, the people inside frantically trying to escape the flaming hull. She acted quickly, warping the civilians and the officers to safety before her body was rocked by the combustion. She landed hard, clipping her shoulder and crashing into a shattered signpost. A wave of pain ricocheted through her body, her vision going dim around the edges as she pushed herself up.

Her wrist buzzed and her heart surged, her hands shaking as she opened the alert. Her hope fell as she read the proximity: new hostiles had tripped whatever was left of their safe zone. She looked up, eyes scanning the horizon, trying to spot anything unusual through the mass of burnt buildings and tree stumps. An unsettling thrum began to surge underneath her boots, and she squinted hard, trying to pinpoint the sound.

She felt her heart stop as she saw an ash cloud explode violently into the sky with a loud crack, the horizon fracturing in massive, jagged lines. The ground heaved upward in an unnatural surge, the gravitational plates and foundation pipes all shrilly sounding their alarms before crumbling. She stumbled as three Grymworms burst from the ground, their enormous bodies writhing and crashing through everything in their path. Each worm dwarfed a city block, their segmented bodies dripping with acidic secretion from armoured growths and blackened glass eyes. Their mouths gaped open in ringed spirals of teeth.

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She narrowed her eyes, her mind refusing to register what she was seeing. Atop the centre worm was a massive figure. Easily over thirty feet tall and wrapped in armour the colour of raw pearl and pink fire. It had a jagged horn jutting from the top of its head and hair that hung in long white braids, crackling with energy. Composed, poised, and vaguely feminine. Heavy, barbed chains ran from its gauntleted hands into the flesh around each worm's gaping eye sockets. From the gaping holes in the ground behind it poured swarms of mutated Dregs. Twisted and over-mutated, they crawled over one another in a bloodthirsty frenzy.

Nyx took a step back involuntarily, her heart pounding against her ribs. The toxicity in the air was increasing rapidly, and she searched the sky desperately one more time before lifting trembling fingers to check her comtech one last time.

2 HOURS, 59 MINUTES

Darius wasn't coming.

Chapter 47

Three hours. The numbers on her comtech glowed harsh and sterile. Darius wasn't coming. Nyx stood frozen to the spot, her thoughts jumbling together. Her body seemed to forget how to breathe as the three Grymworms writhed and crashed through the Southline of Blackroot Verge, each a mountain of armour and acid, devouring everything in its path. Her lungs felt burned as she tried to draw in a full breath while her eyes searched frantically for Voxx.

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“Nyx!” His voice cut through the air as he landed next to her in a streak of white and gold, shockwaves cracking the ground. Ash and deteriorating concrete lashed around him, and she noticed his uniform cut and bloodied in multiple places. His wings dragged, the ends torn and scorched as his augment harness flickered with stressed light. Behind him, T.E.B. officers were scrambling into position as their energy shields flickered like dying stars in the haze. They watched with terrified faces as the hordes of Dregs poured from the mouths of the ruptured tunnels, screaming and swarming through what was left of the Verge.

“Eyes front, operative,” Voxx snapped. She nodded, but her legs stood rooted to the spot as the first wave of Dregs hit the farthest T.E.B. line, buckling it and devouring the officers in guttural screams and howls.

“T.E.B.!” Voxx’s roar split the air, finally jolting her into action. “Hard line here! Nothing can breach the Null Zone! Nothing!”

A chorus of strained affirmatives cracked back, and Nyx strode behind him to the head of the line, feeling a cold silver thread of clarity through her mind. She shouldn’t have waited.

Voxx unsheathed his sword, his energy rushing around him in a flash of white, his voice rough: “We have a Cat 5 Aberrant, now dubbed Vermillion 017. Myself and Operative Nyx will head them off.”

She glanced at him, noting the tiny tremor in his sword, and she felt a pang of guilt sweep through her. She quickly unholstered her sickles, her energy rushing around the handles, the blades forming in crackling fissures as she followed Voxx’s quick jog, the first wave of Dregs already trying to avoid Voxx’s blinding light.

Acid blood whipped across her face as she sank her jagged blades into the clawing bodies in front of her. Claws and overgrown limbs tore at her as she began folding space around her,

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their roars turning into terrified shrieks as her energy disintegrated them into nothing but ash in the wind. She felt each body, their spun-out mutations dragging at the very fabric of her being as they clawed at her.

She began lancing through their bodies with jagged spikes of obsidian and glass, impaling them before cutting through them in a bright spray of acid and blood.

“Nyx! Watch out!”

She pivoted, pulling a shield up of debris as a Grymworm’s bulky head slammed into her. The impact sent shockwaves up her arms as its rows of teeth threatened to consume her. She saw a flash of white overhead before a blade came down in a scouring line of white, lighting the field up brighter than day. Voxx cleaved through the back of the worm, disappearing down its back. She pulled her energy around it, its body impaled on jagged spikes.

She warped in short, vicious hops around the front line, severing and impaling as gut-wrenching screams pierced through the air.

“Focus all fire on the mounts!” Voxx bellowed from overhead. “We’ve gotta break her lead lines!”

Nyx launched herself into the air, whirling to face the nearest Grymworm. She focused her energy on it, lances of energy slamming into it from all sides, keeping it in place. It shrieked in pain, a nauseating blend of metal scraping and animalistic agony, as it thrashed, tearing up the foundations in chunks of flying metal and burnt scraps. She reached for time, her body screaming in protest, hungry for energy as the threads of energy wound tightly around its armoured body. Its sound flattened and stretched thin, its lurch slowing to a crawl as acid droplets hung suspended from its gaping maw. Voxx’s blade swung with a decisive downstroke, light exploding through the chains and armour in a slow arc of light. She felt pieces of the

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creature's existence dissolving, grinding away into nothing as the time around it moved on. The Dregs on either side tried to escape, but she dragged them back, disintegrating them as her energy lashed out desperately, trying to protect her body and feed. Her vision fuzzed in and out as the worm finally collapsed in a shuddering heap of armour and parts. The first worm was dead.

Before she could catch her breath, something bright and fast flashed through her peripheral vision. 017 lifted one heavy hand, the chains snapping taut, and both remaining Grymworms surged in perfect synchronisation towards the T.E.B. line. Behind them, the Dregs shifted suddenly, from a mindless rush into protective clusters around the remaining worms.

"They're not just spun-out," she breathed, her heart stuttering. "How is she controlling them?"

She heard Voxx's voice crackle through the squad channel: "Nyx, you take the left worm, I'll take the right! We collapse to the centre on my mark!"

She forced her shaking legs to move forward, warping high above the leftmost Grymworm, air tearing past her ears. For a heartbeat, she saw the Verge beneath her in brutal clarity, the broken streets and burning husks of buildings. The line of T.E.B. officers was running thin, and she lanced down walls of energy and twisted debris to shield them from the worst of the onslaught before turning her attention to the writhing mass of claws and teeth beneath her. She felt a spike of shame cut through the exhaustion. If she hadn't waited for help, and now this was the price they were paying. She shoved both hands out, her energy lancing from her palms into the armour plating along its skull and down its side. It bucked and screamed as layers of flesh were stripped away in a storm of dissolving fragments as calcified bone and metal were ripped from its body.

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She barely had time to register she had been hit before her world became a single, screaming nerve. Her eyes went dark as the air to the right of her screamed and a wall of red was on her, its thick fist cutting into her midsection, sending her hurtling into a mountain of burning debris. She felt the Aberrant's acidic gauntlet closing around her throat and warped away, her throat ripping from its grasp like a torn canvas.

She landed hard on a mangled skybridge strut, her vision clouding over as she coughed hard, a physical wall of dust and debris scraping her skin as she fell. She saw the towering scarlet monstrosity turn toward her, zeroing in on the sound before it was on her again, its helm-plates shifting narrower. It vaulted into the air in an impossible arc, chains snapping taut around her like comet tails. Nyx dodged hard, throwing up shields as the crackling lightning speared into the concrete around her, trying to skewer her body into place. It hit the skybridge like a meteor, the already shaky concrete shaking beneath Nyx's feet as she warped just out of its trap, reappearing behind its shoulder with her sickles already in motion.

She drove the jagged blade down the seam between its armour plates and neck, her energy creating a localised nova that ate through the metal armour. It roared, lashing out at her as it spewed acidic blood from its wound. It pivoted at the waist, its backhand swinging in a blurred arc connecting with Nyx's ribs.

The world dissolved into white, soundless pain as she felt a muffled crack in her body. All the air in her lungs was replaced by liquid fire, her body floating momentarily before she connected with the broken street below. The impact travelled through her body in a wave of nauseating agony as she rolled and skidded through the ash and fluids.

She pushed herself up, already lashing out at the waves of Dregs trying to swarm her body, cutting through them in desperation and rising anger. Above her loomed a very wounded

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Grymworm, half its skull a smouldering crater as it roared to the ground in pain, trying to escape the frenzy.

“We need help!” a voice streamed over the comms in pure panic. “We’re being pushed toward the Null! We need reinforcements now!”

017 landed before her with a crunch that deformed the street into a crater; one shoulder was lower from its neck wound, and it radiated hate. Nyx warped away again as its boot came down with the intent to shatter her legs, her world snapping sideways in a bloodied frenzy as her energy reserves screamed. She landed on the wounded worm, her boots slipping on the slick bone and exposed tissue. 017 was already following her though, using her chains as grappling hooks and burying them into the worm’s flesh as she hauled herself up the vertical surface in almost an instant.

“Nyx!” Voxx’s voice rang out above her as he descended in a rush of smoke and white, one wing visibly damaged, his sword a streak of light. “Drop!”

She let her legs give way as 017 swiped to grab her, its chains barely missing her face as Voxx’s sword split through its body in a gas of incandescent light and shattered pearl.

It roared in fury and pain, lashing out blindly, a dome of raw concussive force erupting from it, catching Voxx full in the chest. There was a sound like a bell cracking, and he was flung backwards like a ragdoll, disappearing into a plume of dust and debris.

Myth felt panic flood through her as he hit the worm’s lurching neck, the impact jolting a cry from her. She clawed for a grip, her fingers sinking into the burning flesh. The Grymworm was thrashing in its death throes as she shoved her hands deeper, splaying her fingers and unleashing her energy into it.

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The Grymworm screamed with a seismic shudder as its colossal weight slammed into the street, carving a deep ravine as geysers of ash and acid spewed into the air. She couldn't feel her hands and her vision was a grey tunnel, but she breathed a sigh of relief. They had killed one.

The remaining Grymworm was now charging down the slope, a living battering ram as Dregs swarmed over it like armoured lice. And the third worm... wait, where was the third?

"Eyes on the third worm!" she rasped into her comtech, her fingers numbly flying over the cracked surface. "We need a scan of the subsurface!"

"It dove!" a tech's voice crackled back shrilly. "Tremors vectoring straight for the Null Perimeter!" The comms dissolved into chaos, and Nyx flicked it off.

A screech of metal rang through the air, and Nyx's eyes flew to the ravine. 017 rose in front of the crater of the dead worm, half her torso cracked open, its armour hanging in ruined plates. She turned jerkily toward Nyx, its broken horn lowered with murderous hate.

Myth felt an overwhelming wave of fear crash through her. They were all going to die here. She had escaped death over and over, and finally her luck had run out.

017 raised its hands, crimson palm-plates splitting open, revealing swirling mutative cores of energy, rose-gold spheres that hummed in a painful pitch. Her own mutation ached and reached out for the energy, only to be ionised away. They were weapons. It was going to blast the packed, retreating line; it would be a massacre.

From the dust behind it, Voxx emerged, his face a bloodied mask of anger. His chestplate was cratered and hanging on with one strap. His wings were combined into two massive arcs of crystal plumage. He moved between 017 and Nyx, motioning to the retreating T.E.B. squadrons.

"Get. Up. Myth," he said, his voice low. "You have to warp them out of here."

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Move! Her mind screamed at her as she scrambled away, blood flying from her mouth as she coughed heavily from the pain. She warped to the back of the line, stumbling over the mounds of bodies that the officers were using as a makeshift barricade. She began warping them away in painfully eviscerating jerks. Her energy ripped from the core of her being as she warped the officers to Rhea's Helion med-bay, the easiest spot she could remember. Three officers hobbled to her in the haze, relief on their faces as they screamed for help. They blinked away in cheers, and she felt a sense of painful relief. She pushed harder, running through the wreckage even though her muscles spasmed tortuously.

"Is there anyone left?!" she screamed into her flickering comtech. It buzzed uncertainly for a moment, and she looked around frantically, trying to see movement in the bowels of burning bodies and metal.

"Negative. Free to engage." A voice crackled back.

Relief and fear threatened to overtake her as she turned and made her way back to where the rush of Dregs and the Grymworm were fleeing to the unprotected Null. She saw Voxx in the smog, his sword swinging in a dreadful luminescent arc as 017's hands detonated in a rush of gold and rose acidic energy. It flooded through everything left of the blockades and bodies, tearing at her body and flattening everything around them.

She hit the ground hard, her energy surging around her body in a black cocoon, shielding her from the brunt of that blast. Her cheek cut into the ground as the pressure roared around her, sliding her sideways in the blood and muck.

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Then it was gone, leaving nothing but a ringing quiet. Her energy subsided slowly as she pushed herself up to see the entire area had been stripped and melted down to its bare bones. She realised she couldn't hear the sounds of the Dregs anymore, no hum of energy beneath her feet or whispers in the wind.

"Null Zone perimeter breach confirmed," a static-ridden voice scratched through her comtech on the AAN official line. "Third worm has penetrated. As of this moment we have officially lost Gate 3. AAN escorts en route. Maintain your position until further notice."

Every breath felt like a knife twisting in her ribs, and she looked around frantically for Voxx. The world around her unfolded like a terrible fever dream. Explosions of gas fires rocked the distant wreckage as the destruction slowly spread, pouring more ash and soot into the already thick, deadly air. She finally spotted Voxx in the wreckage, sitting hunched over next to the scattered, scarlet remains of Vermillion 017 and the Grymworm she had been riding. The once-bright armour was dull now, the split core revealing its carbonised wiring and strange, glassy bones. It smelt strongly of acid and burnt meat, and she automatically covered her nose.

Voxx looked at her with a sour look, his wings laid behind him in magnificent arches of fractured crystal and light. His armour was layered with soot and acid scars, his chestplate completely gone, exposing his bare chest to the harsh wind.

"Voxx," she started, her voice a dry rasp.

He turned his head away from her, his breath fogging the air in a rough huff.

"I..." she tried again, "I got the T.E.B. out before the blast went off."

Slowly, he turned his head back to her, his silver eyes dimmer and now clouded with pain and fatigue. He looked at her for a long moment before looking past her, the Null perimeter now wailing in the distance in a desperate song. When he finally spoke, his voice was flat. "The third

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worm is inside the Null; Gate 3 is gone. The monsters we didn't kill are going to have access to every part of Titan now." He sighed heavily.

Her body shook involuntarily, the weight of her decisions mixing bitterly with her starving mutation. Her blood was rushing in her ears as she surveyed the carnage.

"I gave you a direct order." He finally pulled himself up, his muscles shuddering with the effort. "This whole mess," he gestured around him, "could have been done and taken care of, but you," he laughed harshly, "you did this."

Ice seeped into her bones, cutting through her fog of exhaustion as the weight of the truth slammed into her. She had been arrogant and thought she could save everyone, and this was the outcome. "I..." The word died on her tongue bitterly. What was there to say? I'm sorry seemed almost like an insult in this situation.

Voxx was looking at her, an unreadable look in his eye, his face tight. He glanced back to the dead monster, the disappointment on his face palpable. "Save it. You'll need your words for the tribunal. They'll want to hear your reasons, and they are going to expect me to give a report." He ran his hand angrily through his hair, and for the first time Nyx could remember, he looked uncertain.

A high, clean whine began cutting through the deep rumble of the distant fires, and she turned her eyes to the white transport bodies, their searchlights cutting through the filth and gloom. Her eyes stung from the cutting wind as she steeled herself.

They descended slowly, the white hull cutting through the smoke as it carefully found footing in the debris and carnage. Her world narrowed as the ramp opened in a rectangle of starkness, crushing the remains of bodies in a sickening crunch as it connected with the ground.

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AAN officers in immaculate white-and-gold armour ran down the walkway, fanning out in practised efficiency. The lead officer's visor covered his face, a distorted mirror of indifference shielding her from his scrutinising eyes. "Operative Nyx, remain where you are."

The officers delicately picked their way through the rubble before standing in a neat formation. "By directive of the Aegis Ascension Council, you, Operative Nyx, are under federal arrest." His voice was devoid of emotion as he read off the litany of charges against her. "Charges are: wilful disobedience of an AAN Commander, unsanctioned deployment of Quasar-tier mutation in a non-sanctioned theatre, for the confirmed slaughter of eighty-seven Blackroot Verge constituents within your operation radius, and on active suspicion of collusion and treason against Titan."

She looked down numbly at her hands. They were flaking from the acid and covered in grime and blood, the heavy metal restraints snapping coldly around her hands and wrists in a flourish. The dampener fields activated with a low thrum and the last of her power drained out of her body. Her thoughts were a dark jumble as her world became small and deafeningly quiet.

She looked to Voxx, but he was already talking loudly with another officer, his hand waving off toward the breach in an agitated manner. Her legs buckled as they dragged her abruptly through the wreckage back to the waiting transport. Her body shook violently as she was hauled aboard, the Verge disappearing behind her in a snap of white. She tried in vain to pull her energy together, to warp away, but she had nothing left.

The gig was up.

Chapter 48

The flight back to Helion was short and uncomfortable. She sat locked into a metal restraint frame bolted to the transport wall, with her wrists locked to a magnetised bar across her lap. A dampener collar rested tightly around her neck and back, but she welcomed the steady hum keeping her energy trapped, unable to lash out. Myth shifted; her breathing was painful and shallow, and every jolt of the transport hull sent a lance of pain through her body.

Two enforcement officers stood on either side of her, their pristine white-and-gold armour a stark contrast to her torn and bloodied uniform. They didn't even look at her. None of the officers looked at her, but they never took their hands off their weapons, as if they were afraid of her.

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She tried to look out the window behind them, but the world was dark and she had no idea what time it was, but her heart ached with worry. She hadn't heard from or seen Darius for hours, and she hoped he wasn't injured or worse.

The transport shuddered as the engines cycled down with a dying whine. A mechanical click resonated through the hull as they docked, the lead officer tapping the intercom. "Dock secure. Preparing to disembark with the asset."

The harness holding her shoulders released with a clang and the officers swarmed around her, their motions quick and stiff, trying to avoid contact with her by any means necessary. Dizziness swamped her as she stood up, a grey tide rising behind her eyes as the blood rushed from her head. Her knees popped loudly, her midsection screaming in agony. The collar gave a sharp buzz, her energy flattening painfully in her chest.

They marched her down the ramp into the cavernous corridor of white bioluminescent stone accented with golden metals and jewels. She knew exactly where she was: the High Tribunal Complex. Its pure, colossal scale was suffocating, the ceiling vaulting away into the gloom, the many columns and arches refracting the light in perfect lines.

Her boots, still crusted with Blackroot's ruin, crunched uncomfortably during the silent, short walk. The officers moved around her with perfect precision, their weapons trained on her head as they moved through the freezing halls. They stopped at a recessed alcove sealed with a massive door of reinforced steel and smoked glass. She heard a faint beep and the door slid open with a heavy groan.

"Inside. Hold your position until further notice," the lead officer barked at her.

She stepped in, the floor rings automatically attaching to her ankle restraints with a definitive clunk. The door groaned shut behind her, muting the corridor sounds entirely.

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She sighed heavily, turning to look at the chamber outside her glass cage. The chamber itself was dark, black drapes hanging over rows of chairs and pews, gold lettering glinting faintly in the dim light. The main doors of the tribunal chamber dominated the far wall, plated with dark, non-reflective alloy and etched with the AAN crest. Lesser doors on either side began immediately to bleed a stream of people into the hall. Delegates in severe black suits, military officers with rows of ill-gotten medals, civilian functionaries, and reporters clutching dim datapads—all moving with a hushed gravity. They seated themselves in the ringed tiers, whispering among themselves as screens floated in the space in front of them, ready to display whatever angle the Council chose.

A large screen blinked brightly on the far wall, causing her to squint her eyes at the sudden light. The text crawl was relentless:

NULL ZONE INCIDENT 01: BLACKROOT VERGE // GATE 3 STATUS: LOST //
BLAROVERG SECTORS 5, 6, 7A: BIOLOGICAL CONTAMINATION 100% //
CONFIRMED DEATHS: 187 (COUNT UNFINISHED) // TRIBUNAL SESSION QP3947

Brutal footage played on a loop like a specially curated nightmare: Dregs boiling from tunnels, a Grymworm's silhouette against a burning district. The frame zoomed in on a blurred figure warping across the field.

She watched herself jerk in and out of frame as the feed struggled to keep up, each warp causing it to glitch in a bloom of violet energy. Her throat tightened as she looked back out over the sea of faces still piling in, the dim hall filling in slow, deliberate rings. From her vantage point she could see everything, suspended over the tribunal chamber like an exhibit on display.

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Her boots left faint smears on the reinforced glass beneath her, skewing the faces of the people filling in below her.

She tried to straighten, but the ache in her ribs stopped her mid-breath, the collar tightening momentarily and painfully around the base of her skull. She tried in vain to calm the rising tide of fear as a figure below pointed to her, then to the screen, their motions strained and abrupt. She looked to the screen to see the number of confirmed deaths slowly ticking up by twos and threes. Her stomach lurched and she swallowed hard, the motion grinding against her bruised cartilage.

She heard a shift below her and saw the tide of bodies part as a knot of familiar uniforms cut through.

Eira had arrived amid a cluster of Cryothorne officers, their white-and-blue frost-crystalline patterns a stark contrast to the dark around them. Her hair was pulled back tightly and her uniform was pristine, making Myth feel even more conscious of her own torn and bloodied uniform. Eira's eyes lifted slowly to the cage, and Myth could feel her cold hate as they locked eyes for a heartbeat before Eira turned away with disgust.

Shame crawled slow and cold through her body as she watched them take their seats, their anger and fear evident on their faces.

A moment later, the Apex Corps delegates walked in, with Darius leading the pack. Her heart slammed in her chest, relief flooding through her. He was dressed in a sharp black-and-gold uniform, his hair damp and steaming visibly in the dark. His expression was calm, but the air around him wavered with heat, the other Apex delegates unable to follow too closely.

He didn't look at her at all; instead, he marched to the back of the tribunal to stand stiffly along the back wall, his eyes fixed firmly on the empty dais. She felt a sudden sting in her eyes,

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and she wanted to cry out to him, partially in relief and partially in fear. She willed him to look up at her, to help her, but his eyes stayed trained straight ahead.

She finally gave up on getting his attention and focused once again on the streams of people entering the hall. A swath of green and white moved into the lower-left tier, and she squinted in the dim light, trying to make out the lead figure.

Rhea. She felt a trickle of relief seeing the emerald surgeon, but it was quickly replaced with worry. Rhea was limping, her medical coat open and bloodied, like she had just been pulled from a surgery. Dark bruises and cuts covered her normally perfect skin, her mutation having clear problems absorbing the injuries she had tried to heal. Her face was pale and strained, and she was surrounded by a swarm of medics and aides in matching green uniforms, with Dr. Ekros bringing up the rear. Unlike the others, he seemed in a rather cheery mood.

Rhea's eyes finally found hers, and she stopped dead, causing a few aides to stumble around her. Her eyes were wide with shock, her lips parted like she was about to call out, her hand lifted towards the glass. A security attendant murmured something in her ear and Rhea flinched visibly, lowering her hand limply to her side.

Myth swallowed hard, her throat scratching painfully. Shame and fear dug in deeper, her mind twisting her thoughts into a fearful vision of death. Ekros's eyes were fixated on her cage, his face bearing a tiny hint of a smile. His red glasses and teal gloves were notably missing, but that only spurred on her worried thoughts.

More uniforms straggled in as the chamber's noise began to thin and a hush rippled through the lowest levels. High Chancellor Mereen entered, her stark white-and-gold uniform almost blinding in the light. She was flanked by Helios King, his armour polished to a high

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gleam and his jaw set tight in visible fury. Voxx brought up the rear, still in his uniform from the Verge, but his chestplate had been replaced with a tight silken cover.

The room rose instinctively as they crossed to the raised dais, Mereen taking the central seat with King on her left and Voxx settling to her right. The rest of the Council filed in around them in a crescent of cold, calculating faces. She saw Voxx lean over and whisper something to Mereen; she nodded discreetly, her jaw flexing slightly.

A clear chime rang through the chamber abruptly, drawing Myth's attention.

"To order," a deep voice ordered over the speakers hidden throughout the chamber.

A soft rustle echoed through the halls as the attendees took stiff seats.

The High Chancellor stood, her face slightly raised to where Myth was sitting.

"Subject 001X, formerly known as Operative Nyx. You are here today to stand trial for your crimes against the AAN and against Titan." She paused slightly before continuing in a voice that carried like hard glass. "The charges read as follows: Class-Omega biological destabilisation, sanctioned predatory parasitism of Apex-tier citizens, and wilful endangerment of the Helion Prime tectonic grid. Wilful disobedience of an AAN Commander, unsanctioned deployment of Quasar-tier mutation in a non-sanctioned theatre, for the confirmed slaughter of eighty-seven Blackroot Verge constituents within your operation radius, and on active suspicion of collusion and treason against Titan. How do you plead?"

The chamber erupted in pandemonium, the fear from the gallery almost palpable. Myth gulped hard, trying to clear her throat.

"I plead not guilty."

Chapter 49

Darius could barely contain the surge of emotions running through him as the High Chancellor read off the charges. He could barely even see Myth from where he was standing, but he knew she could see him clearly. He had made it to Rhea with time to spare, but every remedy she synthesised had to be sent over to Ekros's team, and they had countered every solution with another problem. He helped where he could, but the internal process dragged, allegedly due to infrastructure damage. But his gut told him there was something more. And now...

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“I plead not guilty,” her voice rasped out above him. He felt his back light up as his grandfather stood up in a fiery column, shouting loudly as the chamber around them erupted in a roar of voices.

He turned stiffly to look where Commander Voxx stood motionless. Voxx was covered in blood and grime, his face pulled taut. He didn’t move, just waiting silently as Mereen rapped her gavel for quiet.

“**Order!**” Her voice cut through the din. “Operative. As it seems you are without counsel, counsel will be provided for you. Until that can be arranged, you will be remanded to torpor emergency confinement. Dismissed.”

Darius half-turned, his ears picking up Eira's shrill voice above the din. “This was supposed to be her tribunal! They pulled us all here for *this*?!”

His mind churned; she was right. Something terrible was happening. Fane was still on the loose, an untold number of Dregs and monsters were in the Null Zone, and part of Titan was burning. He scanned the gallery, finally finding the face he was looking for. Ekros was smiling widely, waving his hands excitedly as he spoke to a set of T.E.B. officers. Darius felt his stomach churn as he tried to make his way over, but the imposing figure of General Titus Valkyrie blocked his path.

“We need to talk,” his grandfather barked over the din.

Darius nodded and followed his fiery back out into a side hallway, the sounds of the tribunal echoing away eerily.

“I saw you put in a request for permanent bonding with that **traitor**,” his grandfather sneered as soon as the door clicked behind them.

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He gulped but stayed silent; there was nothing he could say that wouldn't incriminate him more.

"I get word from the High Chancellor, not from you, or from that green medic girl. But the High Chancellor of Titan!" The General almost screeched.

Darius flinched involuntarily as the old man raised a fist at him.

"I will tell you this once, **dog**. You will neutralise this threat. Once and for all. Or I will do it myself." His grandfather grinned wickedly. "And this time, I won't miss."

Darius felt his jaw go slack as the General turned on his heel and stalked back into the tribunal. *This time?* His mind whirled as he strode hastily toward the medical centre of the complex. Helios and his grandfather had been on a joint mission years ago at the personal request of the High Chancellor. He had been a kid then, but he remembered them going to 'deal with' a Quasar-level flashcracking. There had been so much collateral damage that nothing in the area remained inhabitable, the land slowly becoming part of Nocturne. There had been no bodies left, and neither had reported the true death toll, but Darius knew it had been in the thousands. That area had been highly populated, and no evacuation warning had ever been recorded.

He shook his head as he rounded the corner, his eyes catching sight of Ekros. He felt his blood run cold and fire leap from his gauntlet as he strode to catch up with him.

"Ekros!" he roared, the doctor almost jumping out of his skin.

The old man turned and smiled warily at him. "Oh. Valkyrie, what can I do for you?"

"We need to talk," Darius hissed. The doctor nodded once before jutting his chin towards a side door. Darius followed and watched him carefully as the man in the teal coat punched in a code, the door sliding open silently. Inside was already swarming with T.E.B. officers, all with weapons drawn and set to kill. They were finishing strapping down a very exhausted-looking

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Myth, carefully securing the heavy metal frame of the restraints around her. His stomach dropped, but he kept his composure, refusing to look into her eyes. The room quickly emptied except for the doctor and his captive, but Darius could see the faint, watchful eyes behind the viewing glass.

“What are you going to do? I have orders from—” he started, but Ekros cut him off with a giddy wave.

“Oh, shoo your orders. I am following the High Chancellor's orders, and her orders only. And she ordered me not only to put your partner under, but to understand her powers. Scientifically.”

Myth startled behind him, and he turned just in time to dodge a weak wave of energy. Before he had time to react, Ekros was already on her, a large needle stabbing deep into her neck. His hands were, for once, were ungloved and pale, wrinkled fingers were digging deep into her temples. Her eyes looked for help wildly, but Darius stood frozen to the spot. He watched in horror as Ekros's powers flared, his own mind whirling in pain just from being in proximity to the old rat's psychic invasion. `

He moved to interfere, but his grandfather's words echoed through his head: “*You will neutralise this threat. Once and for all. Or I will do it myself...*”

Again.

He needed solutions. Looking one last time at Myth's tormented face, he turned and stalked out the door, his ears ringing as she screamed after him. His eyes stung as he picked up speed, sprinting down the hallway, his mind whirling. If he did anything other than let Ekros handle her, he would sacrifice everything. Fire and Magma poured off him in waves as he pulled

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up short at the viewing room. Commander Voxx stood outside, his shoulders slumped and his resonance so dim Darius almost didn't notice him until he was a foot away.

Before he could speak, the haggard-looking man clamped him hard on the shoulder, pulling him the rest of the way into the corridor.

"I need you to go to the main entrance," the Commander said earnestly, his voice low. "What you do there... it will decide everything."

Darius frowned, torn between staying close by for Myth and following a direct order. "Sir—"

"That is an order, Captain." Voxx's hand was almost bruising on his shoulder.

"I can't just leave my partner, sir! Not again!" Guilt flashed through Darius's body, but he pushed it down. The look in Voxx's eyes made him hesitate. "What is happening at the entrance?"

"If you ever want to see Myth alive again, you will do as I say. Without you, she will die tonight." The Commander straightened, an impassive mask falling over his features. "That is all, Captain."

Darius nodded, slowly backing away before turning and running at full speed towards the stairs, his mind reeling. Myth. Had Voxx known who she was this whole time? The thought echoed through his head as he dropped down the open well of the stairs, his mutation roaring in response to the rapid rush of air. He couldn't slow his thoughts, his mind racing as fast as he fell. What was happening at the entrance? The look in Myth's eyes as he left burned in his brain, the look of complete betrayal. He felt the building vibrate slightly around him as he landed hard, immediately surrounded by blaring klaxons and warning sirens stuttering overhead.

**E-E-EVACUATION PRO-P-PROCEDURES INITIATED: ALL PERSONNEL
PLEASE EXIT IMMEDIATELY—**

Darius turned just in time to shield himself with a thin wall of Magma before the entrance blew inward in a rain of glass, metal, and concrete debris. Aides and techs scurried around him, fleeing out the back exits and down stairwells. He squinted through the haze to see a mountain of a man wearing an Apex-scale mecha-suit in the courtyard. The ground around him was heaving unnaturally, massive fissures splintering up the front of the building, threatening the entire structure.

He felt his blood run cold as he shouted into his comtech, “Mayday! Mayday! Tribunal Complex entrance is under attack! Requesting immedi—”

A wall of flying metal slung him sideways into a pillar, his comtech shattering on contact. He felt a growl leave his throat, but welcomed the physical pain, focusing on the massive assailant. When had Dregs been so bold as to attack a high-security complex? He didn’t have time to ponder as he quickly dodged another barrage of metal and concrete, the building behind him shuddering as it began to sink backwards with a sickening crunch.

He felt his bones rattle as another seismic wave tore through him; his body, already exhausted from the day's events, fell sideways hard. His eyes caught a glimpse of a dark figure behind the giant before the figure was suddenly on him, the devastated, half-cyborg face of Vexal Ophedius inches from his own.

Before he could react, the insurgent's hand was around his neck, his lips inches from his ear. “Where is Myth?”

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Darius stilled instantly, his jaw slightly agape. “Wha—” He felt a rush of something dark and necrotic wrap around his neck, his mutation sputtering wildly as a suffocating cold began to seep into his bloodstream. Rot.

“If you care at all about her, you will tell me where she is,” Vexal growled under his breath. “We both know she’s running out of time.”

Darius felt the blood drain from his face, his body finally going still. She was an insurgent. The thought screamed through him. He was shaking violently as he stumbled to his feet, the flames around his body only smouldering now under the crushing weight of Vexal's aura. The leash of Rot was still tight around his throat, and he struggled to speak. “The... the medical bay,” he finally stuttered. “But you will never reach her from the inside.”

“Noted.” Vexal turned, dragging Darius behind him like a ragdoll. “We will just scale the outside then.”

“The outside?!” Darius gasped as his body flew through the air, the insurgent racing up the side of the building beside him. Vexal was using powerful vines of Rot to scale the exterior, ash and debris raining down into the deep chasms opening up beneath the complex. The seismic giant’s damage was quickly becoming irreversible.

They were going to kill everyone here. He tried to flare his mutation, but a shockwave of necrotic pain flooded his senses.

“There’s no use struggling,” Vexal huffed beside him. “Tell me what floor she’s on and I won’t kill everyone in this sector.”

“Sixteenth!” he gasped, his body shuddering as he felt his internal temperature drop lower into a freezing void. “Please. Don’t hurt her.”

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“Hurt her?” The Rot Saint’s voice was incredulous. “I am the only chance she’s got right now.”

Darius couldn’t control his face, the pain pouring through his body becoming unbearable. “Here! You will have to break through over ten feet of solid—”

The insurgent was already pouring his Rot into the wall of titanium and steel, purple and black tendrils snaking across the entire middle half of the building in a terrible, decaying web. Ash and liquified metal poured out of the structure, and Darius felt himself being pulled through the opening until a blinding light broke through the dark wall.

Voxx was standing at the command station, his massive wings extended, shielding the other Apexes from the explosion of shrapnel.

“Surrender the subject and pretty boy here lives,” Vexal’s deep voice boomed through the medical bay. Darius’s vision was completely clouded over, but he could feel the Rot around his neck tightening as his feet dangled high above the courtyard below. He would have no way to recover from a drop this high in his weakened state.

I am going to die here...

“We will never surrender to a tyrant!” Mereen’s cold voice rang out from the corner of the room. Darius squinted to take in Voxx, rings ready, but down on one knee as the Rot caved in the floor beneath him. He had never seen a mutation take over a space this rapidly, let alone bring the mighty Commander to his knees. Eira and Lynx were both lying on the ground, their bodies almost completely encased in Rot and shrapnel from the blast. Helios stood frozen to the spot, but Ekros was nowhere to be seen.

“Take her,” Voxx’s voice said coldly.

“Wise choice, old man,” Vexal sneered behind an ever-growing cloud of dark Rot.